PROJECT
/ 01 · 2026

ART · SCIENCE
MENTAL HEALTH



WHAT IS MADNESS?

Art and data on mental health

LABS · INSTALLATION · MAPPING · STREET INTERVENTIONS

LUIZAJESUSDOPRADO.COM

OVERVIEW

FOUR WORKS, ONE DATA TRANSLATION

What Is Madness? is a project of four main works that use open data on what affects mental health in each place in the world. The data are translated into body chemistry, colour and frequency, and become image, light and sound.

Three works are websites that already run, updated automatically from scientific sources and international agencies, in English, Portuguese and Spanish: the Allostatic Load lab, the Observatory and the Mandala of the Unconscious. The fourth, Sirene, is a light and sound object for galleries, with a 3D simulation, images, video and a 3D model ready.

Every week the project publishes an image and sound bulletin on the world's mental health. Part of the income goes to institutions that care for the causes the work shows.

AT A GLANCE

PROJECT AT A GLANCE

TITLE	What Is Madness?
ARTIST	Luiza Jesus do Prado
MEDIA	Art and technology · generative art · light and sound installation · data
WORKS	Allostatic Load (lab) · Observatory · Mandala of the Unconscious · Sirene (installation)
FORMAT	Free, open websites · gallery installation · weekly image and sound bulletin
AUDIENCE	Open to all. The websites need no login or sign-up
STATUS	In development since 2023 · websites ready, open code · Sirene at prototype stage
EXTENSIONS	Nebulae (atlas and light installation) · Map of care and Catalysing Affect (idea in development) · Masks · projection-mapped videos · street interventions (Minhocão, São Paulo)
RESEARCH	Decolonization of mental health
THEORY	Allostatic load (McEwen and Stellar) · Foucault · Nise da Silveira · Frantz Fanon

CONCEPT

WHAT IS MADNESS?

An investigation into suffering, power and the conditions of existence

What do we call madness? Where does the individual end and the world that makes them ill begin?

What Is Madness? is an artistic, scientific and technological investigation into the relations between mental health, conditions of existence and structures of power. It starts from the hypothesis that psychological suffering cannot be understood only as an individual phenomenon, separate from the social, political, economic, historical and environmental conditions in which life takes place.

Human experience is crossed by forces we cannot always perceive directly: violence, hunger, war, precarity, racism, exclusion, isolation, climate change and material insecurity. These conditions do not only organise society. They also run through bodies, nervous systems, processes of adaptation and the possibilities of existing.

By bringing together environmental and social data, neuroscience, biochemistry, image, light and sound, the project seeks to make some of these relations perceptible. Science provides instruments to observe what escapes immediate experience; art creates other ways to experience, interpret and question these phenomena.

The research also turns to the history of psychiatry and to the practices of confinement that turned certain differences, behaviours and forms of suffering into grounds for exclusion. In dialogue with the anti-asylum movement, the Brazilian Psychiatric Reform and decolonial thought, the project asks who has the power to define normality, which lives are considered legitimate and which historical conditions make certain populations more vulnerable to suffering and to institutional violence.

The question is no longer only what happens inside a person, but also what happens around them, to them and through them.

CONCEPT

WHAT IS MADNESS?

From this perspective, madness is not presented as a universal, fixed category independent of context, but as a field of dispute between subjective experience, scientific knowledge, social conventions and relations of power. This does not mean reducing mental disorders to social conditions, but investigating how biological, environmental and historical factors combine in the production of suffering.

The project unfolds into data visualisation systems, generative compositions, light and sound installations, mandalas, objects and interventions in public space. These works turn information into sensory experience and create correspondences between scales: from the molecular to the bodily, from the individual to the collective, from the territory to the planet.

By moving the investigation from the clinic to the gallery and the street, the project also moves the question itself. The city is no longer only the setting where life happens; it becomes an active part of the conditions that shape it.

What is madness? What do we call normality? And what happens when we examine not only those who fall ill, but also the world they are forced to live in?

CONCEPT

FIVE AXES

The project is organised around five connected axes, so that it does not become a collection of separate subjects.

1. THE BODY AS TERRITORY

The body is not an isolated unit: it is a biological system in permanent relation with its environment. Stress, adaptation, metabolism and the nervous system are the entry point to investigate how the conditions of existence affect physiology.

In the project: the Allostatic Load lab, which links each factor to mediators of stress and care.

2. THE MAKING OF NORMALITY

Who defines what is normal, pathological or deviant? The history of the asylum, medicalisation and systems of classification show how knowledge about mental health is also shaped by institutional interests, inequality and exclusion.

In the project: the critique of the asylum and the Masks, in dialogue with Frantz Fanon.

3. THE GEOGRAPHY OF SUFFERING

Different territories produce different exposure to violence, precarity and environmental risk. Data make it possible to investigate these inequalities without treating suffering as a private failure of those who live it.

In the project: the Observatory, which reads each event by place, and Sirene, which changes with the city where it is shown.

4. TRANSLATING THE INVISIBLE

Data, substances, frequencies and statistical relations become image, light, sound and movement. Visualisation is not only scientific illustration: it is a language for producing other forms of perception.

In the project: cymatics, the light of Sirene and the Mandala of the Unconscious, in dialogue with Nise da Silveira.

5. RETURNING TO PUBLIC SPACE

By leaving the gallery and occupying the city, the research turns a question that seems individual into a collective one. Public space becomes a place where experience, knowledge and social responsibility meet.

In the project: the projection-mapped videos and urban interventions, such as at the Minhocão.

CONCEPT

MENTAL HEALTH AND PLACE

THE QUESTION

The project treats mental health as an effect of the place where people live, not only as something individual. If anyone can fall ill under the right conditions, the line between madness and sanity also depends on the world around them. In the first year of the pandemic, anxiety and depression rose by 25% worldwide, according to the World Health Organization (2022). War, hunger, heat and debt push the same way.

ALLOSTATIC LOAD

Allostatic load is the wear the body accumulates from adapting again and again to stress, a concept proposed by McEwen and Stellar (1993). The project applies it to places: it adds up what weighs on the people who live in each one and shows that weight as body chemistry, colour and frequency.

PSYCHOBIOLOGY AS A LANGUAGE

The work uses stress mediators (hormones, neurotransmitters, signals of inflammation and of bonding) as a shared vocabulary between science and art. The translation is stated as a simplification of the literature: it describes tendencies in populations, never anyone's body.

CONCEPT

WHO GETS CALLED MAD, AND WHY?

THE ASYLUM

For centuries the asylum was where society sent the people it did not want to see. In *History of Madness* (1961), Michel Foucault shows that in the seventeenth century the poor, the unemployed and the "mad" were locked up together. In Brazil, at the Colônia hospital in Barbacena, at least 60,000 people died between the 1930s and the 1980s, and about 70% of those interned had no diagnosis of mental illness (Arbex, *Holocausto Brasileiro*, 2013).

THE CRITIQUE

The label "mad" has been used to set apart the poor, Black people, gender dissidents, migrants and those who disobey. The project turns the question around: not "what is wrong with this person?" but "what was done to them, and where do they live?". If war, hunger, heat, debt and racism make whole populations ill, locking up the individual hides the cause.

The project stands with the anti-asylum movement and Brazil's Psychiatric Reform (Law 10.216/2001).

CONCEPT

MANDALA AND MASK

NISE DA SILVEIRA

At Engenho de Dentro, in Rio de Janeiro, Nise da Silveira studied the mandalas painted by patients and founded the Museum of Images of the Unconscious. The Mandala of the Unconscious and the floor mandala of Sirene speak to that work: the form that comes from within.

FRANTZ FANON

At the Blida hospital, in Algeria, Frantz Fanon showed that colonialism makes people ill. In *Black Skin, White Masks* (1952), the mask is the identity imposed by racism. In the project, the mask stands for the label imposed from outside, and the light shows what actually weighs on each place.

DECOLONIZING MENTAL HEALTH

Instead of an individual diagnosis, the project shows the social and environmental factors that make people ill: conflict, hunger, displacement, climate, money. South Sudan, Dhaka and Lagos appear on the same scale as São Paulo and Tromsø, with open data from international agencies.

BACKGROUND: SOCIAL HACKER

The project continues Social Hacker (2019), which investigates the invisible protocols of social life, the codes, permissions and exploits of belonging, through stereograms, agricultural landscapes and systems seen from above. What Is Madness? keeps that view from above: each place is read as a system that can make people ill.

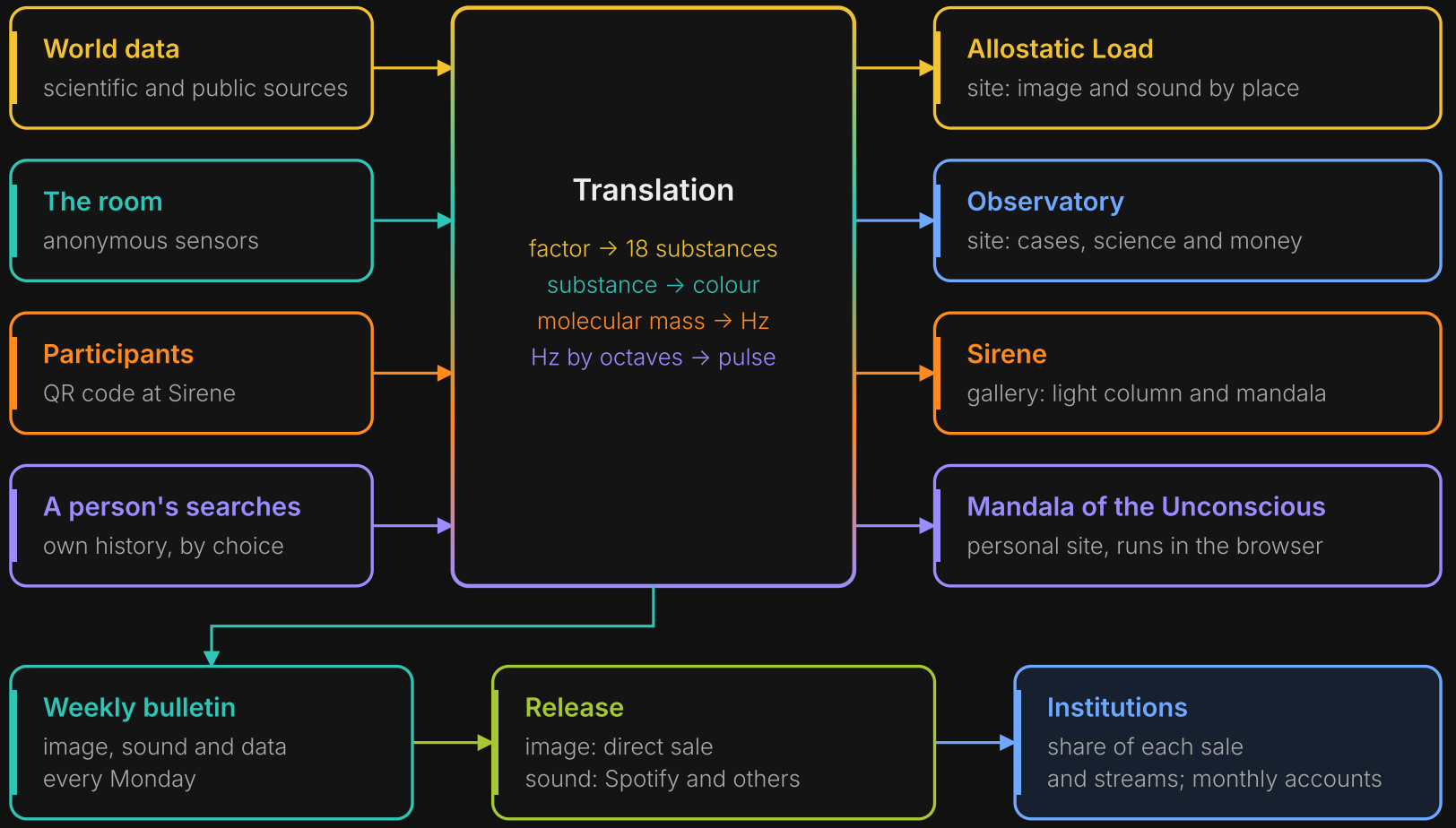
THE COUNTERPOINT OF CARE

Cooperation, aid and searches for support enter the same count and soften the colour and the sound. Every rise points to a response with scientific evidence, such as cash transfers, community listening and brief psychological support.

THE WORKS

HOW THE WORKS CONNECT

One translation links all the works, and part of the income goes back to the causes



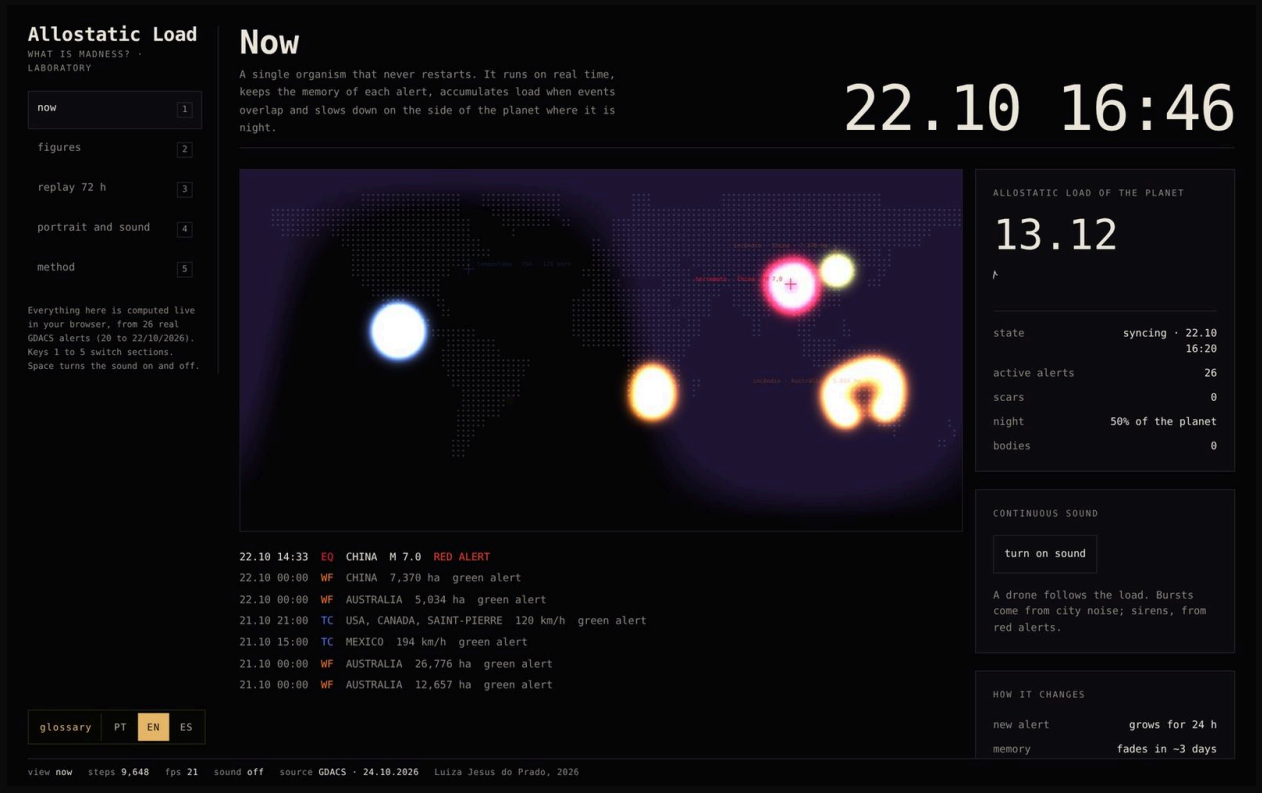
THE WORKS

THE FOUR WORKS

WORK	WHAT IT IS	FORMAT	DATA
Allostatic Load	A lab that turns each place in the world into image and sound from what weighs on the mental health of the people who live there	Website: an organism on the map, network figures, cymatics and continuous sound	Disaster alerts, climate, air, conflict, hunger, economy, humanitarian risk
Observatory	A research panel that links each event to who suffers, who profits, what science shows and what helps	Website: cases, timeline, indices by place, live research, medicines, connections map	Scientific databases, pharmacovigilance, economic indicators, humanitarian crises
Mandala of the Unconscious	Turns what a person searches for online into a mandala of colour, form and sound, with a mode to move towards how they want to feel	Full-screen website; everything runs in the browser and nothing is sent	The person's own search history, by their choice
Sirene	A light and sound object: a column of light with blended colours and a mandala of light on the floor	2.70 m installation with floor projection and continuous sound	The gallery's city, room sensors and visitors via QR code

LAB
/ ALLOSTATIC LOAD

EACH PLACE BECOMES IMAGE AND SOUND



NOW VIEW

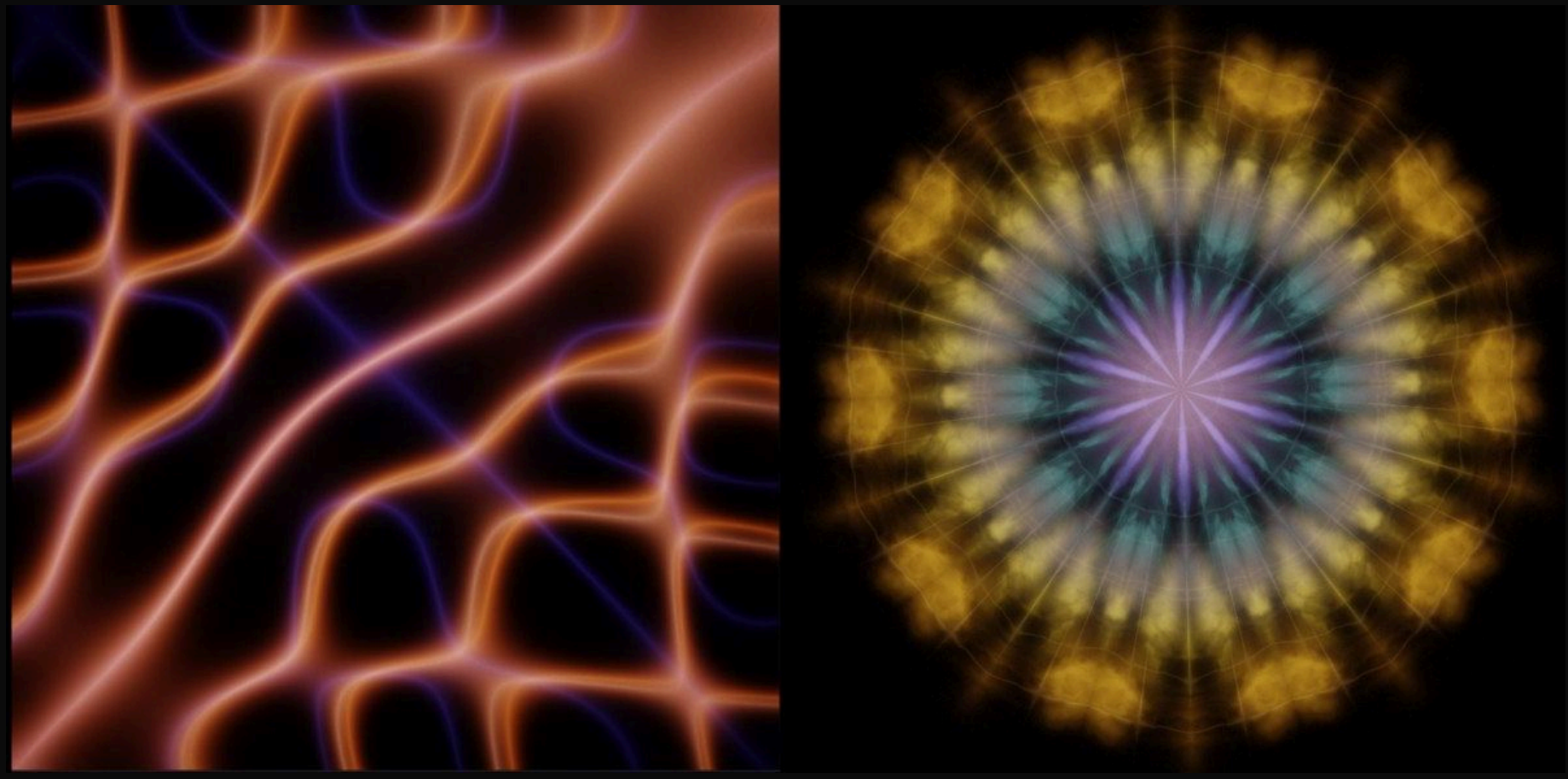
It reads what weighs on the mental health of the people who live in each place and turns it into continuous image and sound. It follows 17 places and the whole world, from South Sudan to Tromsø, with open data from scientific sources and international agencies.

Views: Now, Figures, Replay 72 h, Sound and cymatics, Stereogram, Method. Each has a glossary on its own page.

In the Now view, an organism on the world map grows with every real disaster alert (GDACS) and keeps their memory; beside it, the allostatic load of the planet as a number.

LAB
/ ALLOSTATIC LOAD

CYMATICS AND MANDALA

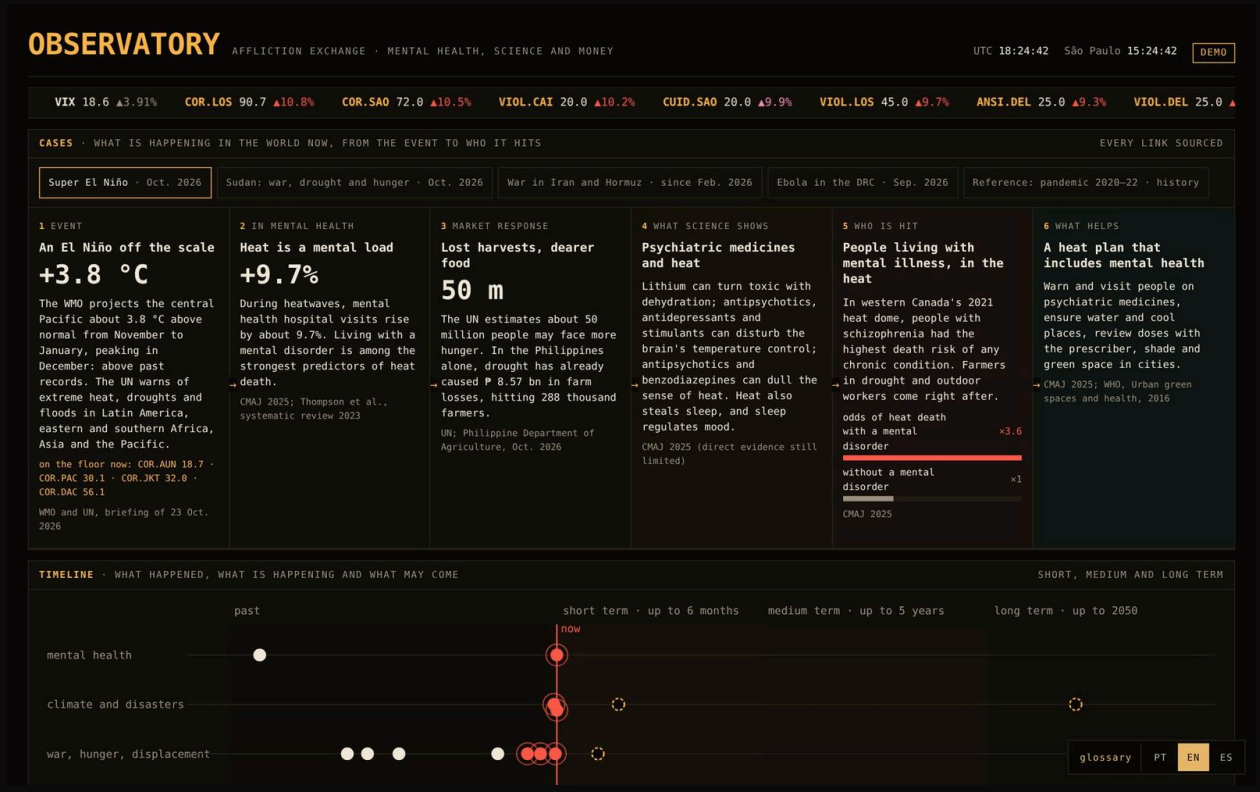


TWO OUTPUTS OF THE LAB FOR SÃO PAULO: CYMATICS AND MANDALA

Each place becomes a moving figure, a reaction-diffusion network; the frequencies of the substances draw Chladni figures, and the sound of the place continues until the person turns it off.

LAB
/ OBSERVATORY

WHO SUFFERS, WHO PROFITS, WHAT HELPS



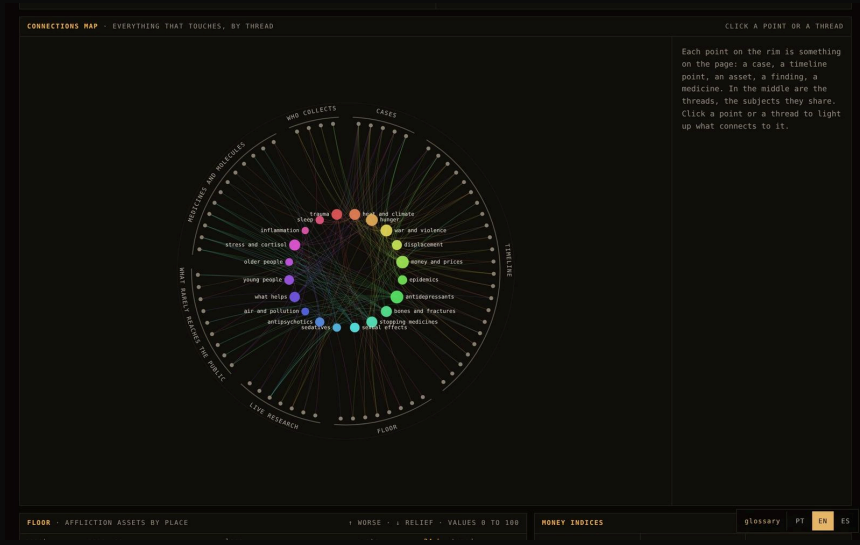
CASES AND TIMELINE

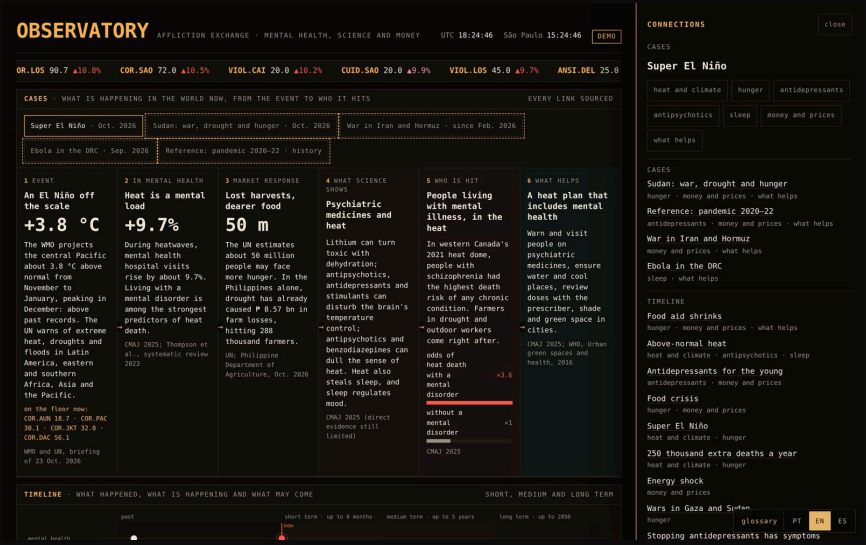
A research panel that crosses each event with mental health. Each case has six columns: the event, the effect on mental health, who profits, what science shows, who is hit hardest and what helps.

It has a timeline to 2050, affliction indices by place, live research (reviews and clinical trials collected daily), little-known effects of medicines, a sound floor, a Bluesky bot and a browser extension.

LAB
/ OBSERVATORY

CLICK AND SEE WHAT CONNECTS



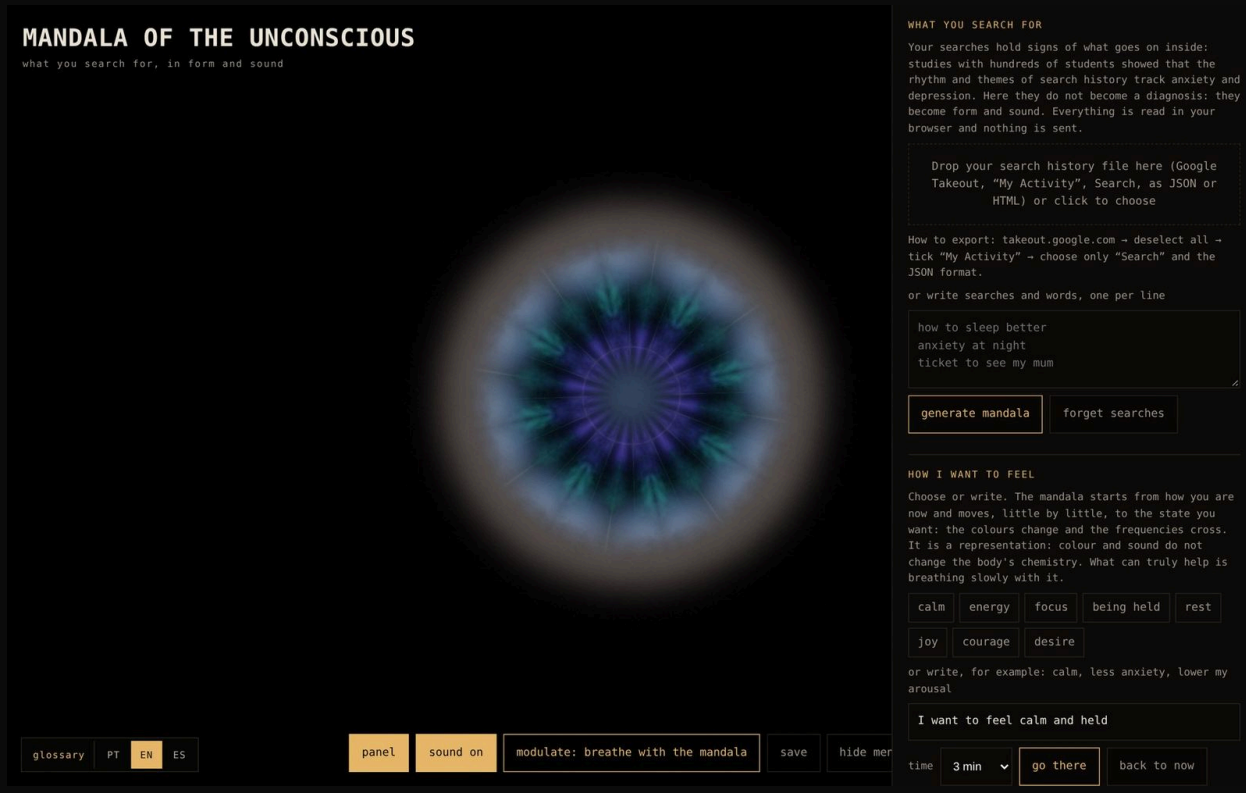


Connections map: each point on the rim is an item on the page, and the threads link what deals with the same theme.

Clicking any item opens a panel with the cases, timeline events, research and medicines on the same thread.

LAB
/ MANDALA OF THE UNCONSCIOUS

WHAT YOU SEARCH FOR, IN FORM AND SOUND



INTENTION MODE

A personal work. The person gives it their own search history (Google Takeout) or types words, and the work draws a mandala of 19 substances in 8 rings, each with its own colour, petals and frequency. Everything is read in the browser and nothing is sent.

In "how I want to feel" mode, the mandala moves slowly from the current chemistry to the desired one; the sound crosses two chords. The menu can be hidden for a full-screen mandala.

It is a representation: it does not act on the body and does not replace health care.

DATA

WHERE THE DATA COME FROM

All data are open and public, from international agencies, scientific institutions and recognised databases. The sources are queried automatically and every query is archived. No source identifies people: the data are aggregated by place.

THEME	SOURCES
Disasters	GDACS (UN and European Commission), USGS (earthquakes)
Heat and air	Open-Meteo, Copernicus CAMS air quality
Conflict and cooperation	GDELT, UCDP (Uppsala University)
Hunger, war, displacement	HDX HAPI (UN OCHA): ACLED, IPC, IOM, UNHCR
Economic indicators	World Bank, FRED (Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis), Stooq
Distress and hope	Wikipedia pageviews in each language and public Bluesky posts, counts only
Science	Europe PMC (articles and reviews), ClinicalTrials.gov (clinical trials)
Medicines	openFDA (pharmacovigilance)
Molecular mass	PubChem (NIH)

HOW IT WORKS

ENVIRONMENT, CHEMISTRY, COLOUR AND FREQUENCY

The translation has three steps and applies to all four works.

1. FROM ENVIRONMENT TO CHEMISTRY

Each environmental factor is linked to the substances the body produces in response, according to the literature on the psychobiology of stress. There are 18 substances, from cortisol and adrenaline to oxytocin and GABA.

FACTOR	SUBSTANCES
Heat	cortisol, vasopressin, serotonin, melatonin, histamine
Polluted air	interleukin-6, glutamate, histamine, substance P
Noise	noradrenaline, cortisol, melatonin, acetylcholine
War	noradrenaline, glutamate, CRH, cortisol, substance P
Hunger	serotonin, ghrelin, cortisol, CRH
Displacement	oxytocin, cortisol, CRH, vasopressin
Economy	cortisol, noradrenaline, CRH, serotonin
Care	oxytocin, GABA, beta-endorphin, anandamide, dopamine

2. FROM CHEMISTRY TO COLOUR

Each substance has a fixed colour: cortisol gold, GABA blue, oxytocin rose, melatonin violet. The weight of each sets its brightness, and the colours blend, because nothing in the body acts alone.

3. ONE FREQUENCY FOR SOUND AND LIGHT

The mass of each molecule becomes a frequency. For sound, it is moved by octaves into the audible range; for light, it keeps going down to the pace of a breath.

SUBSTANCE	MASS	SOUND	LIGHT
Cortisol	362.46	362 Hz	1 cycle / 5.6 s
GABA	103.12	103 Hz	1 cycle / 5.0 s
Oxytocin	1,007.19	1,007 Hz	1 cycle / 4.1 s
Melatonin	232.28	232 Hz	1 cycle / 4.4 s

INSTALLATION
/ SIRENE

LIGHT · SOUND
GALLERY



SIRENE

A column of light and a mandala on the floor

3D SIMULATION · COLOURS OF SÃO PAULO

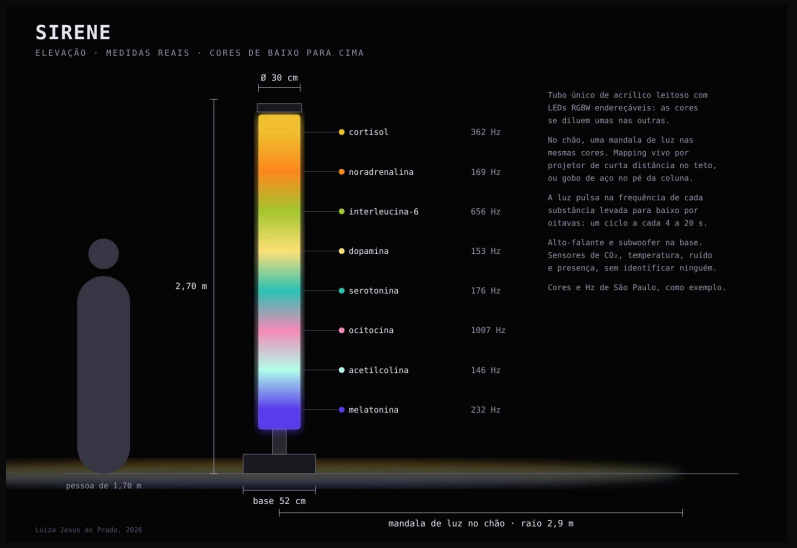
SIRENE
/ THE OBJECT

LIGHT, SOUND AND SENSORS

A 2.70 m column of light with the colours of the substances blended in a single tube, and a mandala of light projected on the floor. The sound is a continuous chord with no alarm, because a siren sound can trigger people.

ITEM	PROPOSAL
Size	2.70 m tall, 30 cm across, 52 cm base
Light	Addressable RGBW LEDs in a milky acrylic tube
Floor	2.9 m radius mandala: short-throw projector (live mapping) or steel gobo (fixed mask)
Sound	Speaker and subwoofer in the base, under 85 dB, with a limiter
Control	Raspberry Pi (sound and data) and ESP32 (light)
Sensors	CO_2, temperature, noise level without recording, anonymous presence

Measurements and parts are the simulation's proposal and will be adjusted in production.



ELEVATION WITH MEASUREMENTS

SIRENE
/ THE FLOOR MANDALA

THE MANDALA KEEPS CHANGING



THE SAME SIRENE WITH THE DATA OF TROMSØ

Each ring is a substance, in the same colour as the tube. The number of axes comes from how many substances weigh at once, from 6 to 16. In live mapping, each ring pulses at its frequency, turns and passes its colour to the next; the drawing remakes itself when the data change.

The room counts too: the city's data, the sensors and the visitors. A QR code opens a page with no login; the person says how they arrived and how they want to leave. Each answer weighs for about two minutes and then fades; nothing is stored.

PROPOSED EXTENSION

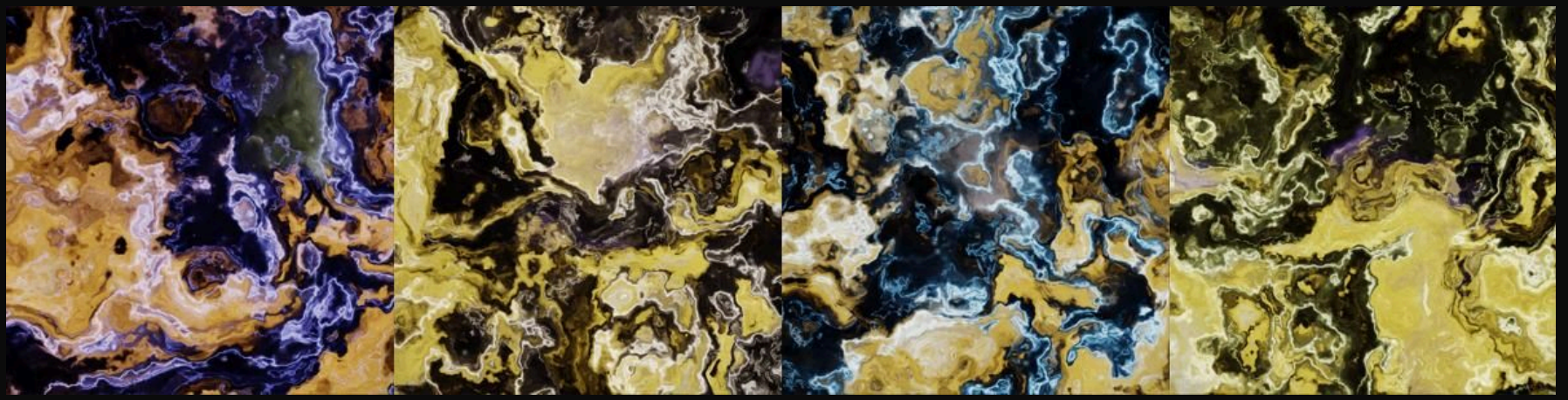
MASKS

An installation of identical white translucent masks, in a ring around Sirene or along a wall. Behind each mask, the light of one place, in the same colour and frequency as Sirene.

The uniform mask stands for the label “mad”, which erases the person; the light behind it shows what weighs on them. Visitors stand between the floor mandala (Nise da Silveira) and the ring of masks (Frantz Fanon).

The proposal does not use masks from specific cultures.

NEBULAE: ATLAS AND INSTALLATION



STUDIES FOR THE ATLAS: NEBULAE GENERATED BY THE LAB

The nebulae leave the lab and become fixed, physical works chosen by the artist: print, light and projection.

ATLAS

A fixed series of 5 to 7 large-format prints or lightboxes. Each image carries the name of a place and the date it was generated. It is neither updated nor sold as a series: it is a record, like the plates of an atlas, tied to the geography of suffering axis.

NEBULA, A LIGHT INSTALLATION

Light passes through a shallow tank of water or through textured or dichroic glass panels and projects clouds and filaments onto the ceiling or wall. A speaker fixed to the tank plays the frequencies of the place's substances, and the water vibrates with them; with glass, the panels turn slowly. The stimulus can also come from the people in the room: breath, pulse or Sirene's anonymous presence and noise sensors. Materials and dimensions will be defined in a prototype.

MASKS

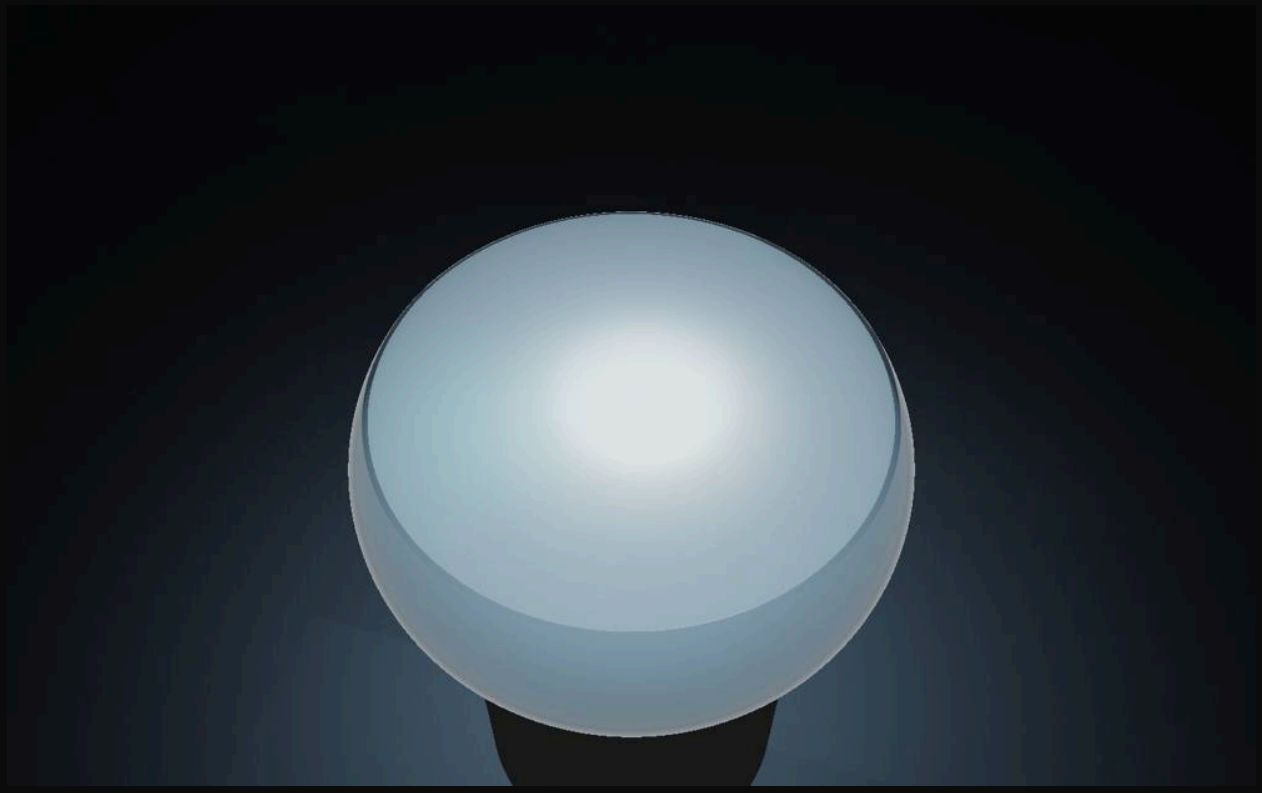
The nebula projected onto the masks: the mask is the label imposed from outside, and the light shows what weighs on each place.

MAPPING

The nebula as the background of the projection-mapped videos, with the project's question.

IDEA IN DEVELOPMENT

MAP OF CARE AND CATALYSING AFFECT



3D SIMULATION: TWO TOUCHES FROM DIFFERENT CITIES MEETING

An idea I want to develop. The map of care already exists online; Catalysing Affect is the installation that grows from it.

MAP OF CARE

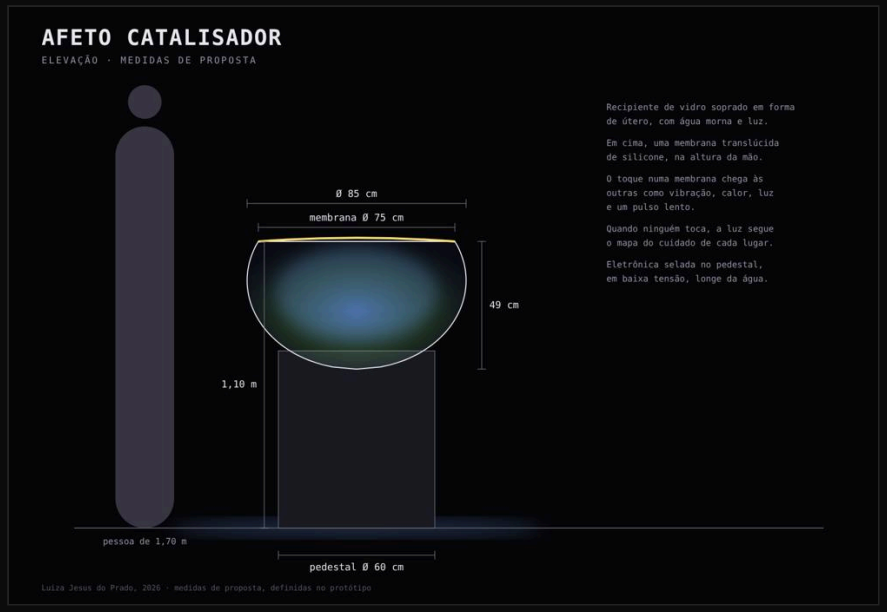
The reverse of the load: where people hold on. Each place's light comes from aid and cooperation reported in the news and from searches and posts of hope; threads link places where care is present at the same time.

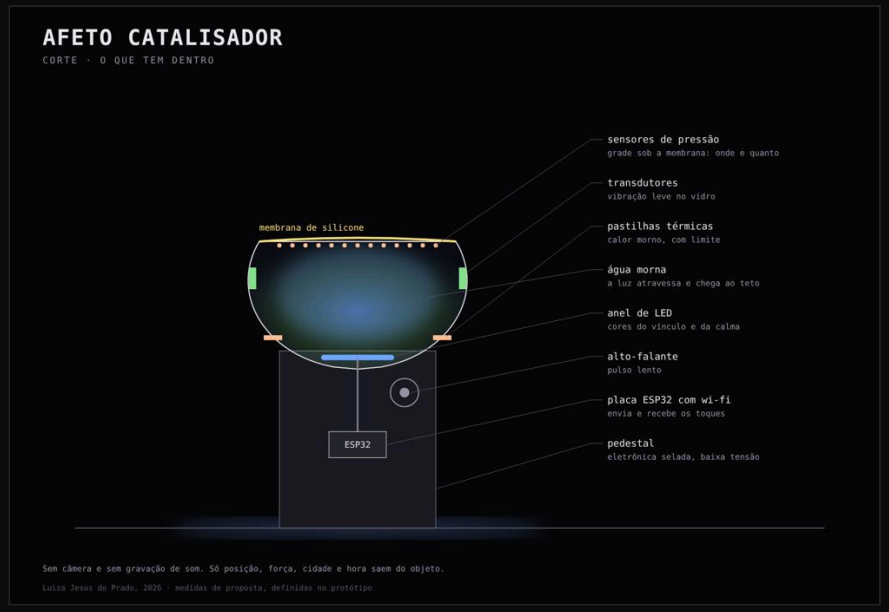
CATALYSING AFFECT

A womb-shaped glass vessel with warm water and light, covered by a translucent membrane, installed in several cities. When someone touches one membrane, the others feel it on the same spot: it vibrates gently, warms a little, lights up in the colour of the place the touch came from, and a slow pulse sounds. Whoever is on the website can touch too. The name comes from Nise da Silveira, who called the bond that helps healing a catalysing affect.

IDEA IN DEVELOPMENT

MAP OF CARE AND CATALYSING AFFECT





ELEVATION AND SECTION, PROPOSED DIMENSIONS

HOW IT WOULD WORK

Pressure sensors under the membrane, vibration transducers and thermal pads on the glass, an LED ring and a wi-fi board. A server only relays position, pressure, city and time. No camera and no sound recording. Proposed size: a 75 cm membrane at 1.10 m from the floor.

STAGES

A prototype of one membrane, then two units linked over the internet, then the website, then institutions in other cities. No partnership is confirmed.

MAPPING
/ STREET

VIDEO · PROJECTION
PUBLIC SPACE



FIRST VIDEO STUDY · 21 S · 1920×1080

MAPPING AND THE STREET

WHAT IS MADNESS? WHAT IS SANITY?

PROJECTION-MAPPED VIDEOS

Projection-mapped videos made from the images the data generate (mandalas, cymatics) and from the project's question. They can be projected on façades, blank building walls and on Sirene itself. The first study already exists: the question in white letters over blue liquid forms.

STREET INTERVENTIONS

The question leaves the gallery for the street, in places people pass through in São Paulo such as the Minhocão (Elevado Presidente João Goulart), the elevated highway that closes to cars and becomes a leisure space at night and on weekends.

Projection mapping on the building walls along the highway, with the project's videos and the city's colours of the day.

Posters and banners with the two questions and a QR code that leads to the lab.

Sirene on the street: a version of the light column in public space, with the same continuous sound and no alarm.

The interventions depend on permits from the City of São Paulo and the building owners. The format can travel to other cities, with the question in the local language.

WEEKLY BULLETIN

EVERY MONDAY: IMAGE, SOUND AND DATA

PIECE	WHAT IT IS	WHERE IT GOES
Image	The substances that weighed most over the seven days, in blended colours, with the week's mandala	Direct sale by the artist, with a share of each sale for institutions
Sound	Seven movements of about one minute, one per day; algorithmic synthesis, not artificial intelligence	Spotify and other platforms, via a distributor
Data	Places with the highest load, alerts, new reviews and trials, the counterpoint and the sources	The project website, in three languages, archived

All three pieces carry the same number (for example, Bulletin 001, week 44 of 2026). Generation is automatic; publishing waits for the artist's approval.

Once a month, the institutions' share is donated, and the website publishes what was raised, what was donated, to whom, with receipts. No partnership is confirmed yet.

CARE

ETHICS, PRIVACY AND SAFETY

No diagnosis. The links between factors and substances describe tendencies in populations. The work does not measure anyone's body and does not act on the body.

Privacy (Brazil's LGPD). At Sirene, no phone is identified and no sound is recorded; only volume, CO_2, temperature and anonymous presence are measured, with a notice in the room. In the Mandala of the Unconscious, searches never leave the browser.

Light. No flashes: the fastest pulse is one cycle every 4 seconds, below the limit of 3 flashes per second used to protect people with photosensitive epilepsy.

Sound. Continuous, no alarm, under 85 dB, with a limiter.

Medicines. The Observatory shows little-known effects without demonizing the pharmaceutical industry and repeats that no one should stop or change a medicine without the person who prescribed it.

Money and suffering. The donated share and the transactions are public and reported every month.

STAGES

STAGES AND CIRCULATION

STAGE	TIMING	WHAT HAPPENS
Launch	weeks 1 and 2	Websites online; project page on the portfolio
Weekly bulletin	weeks 3 to 6	Generation of the image, track and data page; distributor and agreements with institutions
Releases	from week 7	One bulletin a week: image sale and sound on streaming; monthly accounts
Sirene prototype	3 to 4 months	Full-scale prototype of the light tube, sound and sensors; floor mapping test
Mapping and street	in parallel	New mapped videos; permits and first intervention at the Minhocão
Exhibition	after the prototype	Sirene in a gallery, with the online works on screens or projected and the archive of bulletins

International circulation. Sirene changes colour and sound according to the city where it is shown, and the online works are already in three languages. The project seeks partnerships with art, science or mental health institutions in any country to show Sirene and present the weekly bulletin. No partnership is confirmed. Timings are a proposal.



PHOTO: MAURIZIO MANCIOLI

ABOUT THE ARTIST

LUIZA JESUS DO PRADO

Brazilian transdisciplinary artist and researcher. Her work articulates art, science and technology to investigate memory, mental health and trauma, exploring expanded photography, sound and performance. Her bodily practices engage with ritual, gender and decolonial healing processes.

Her research addresses the consolidation and recovery of memory through photographic reprocessing, the decompilation of images and sounds generated from visual data; neurophysiological responses to sensory stimuli; and art as an accessible, non-bureaucratic approach to treatment and harm reduction, drawing on semiotics, neuroscience and psychobiology.

Her work has been shown at biennials including Casablanca and Changjiang and the Off Biennale Cairo, at Pacific Standard Time LA/LA, MAR, Theatro Municipal de São Paulo, CCBB, Museu do Amanhã and ZK/U in Berlin.

luizajesusdoprado.com

SOURCES

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Data sources for each work: the glossary and method page of each website; open code.

Images: screenshots of the websites and 3D simulations made by the artist with her own code.